Making assignment expectations clear

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D10-S1–S6

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Students may understand the assignment topic but be unsure what they must produce, how to approach it or what counts as successful work. Explain these expectations explicitly and check students' interpretation before substantial work begins.

1. Make the purpose, task and requirements explicit

Organise the assignment brief so students can identify why they are doing the task, what they must do and what they must submit.

Example — Business

Element	Example wording
Purpose	Practise evaluating business options and making an evidence-based recommendation.
Task	Compare the two expansion options in the case and recommend one to the management team.
Output	A 1,500-word report using the required report structure.
Evidence	Use the case data and relevant course concepts to support your judgement.
Submission	State the deadline, submission location, file format and any required attachments.

Keep the brief, assessment criteria and classroom explanations consistent. Distinguish requirements from optional suggestions.

2. Explain key task words in the subject context

Identify words that carry important expectations, such as *analyse*, *evaluate* and *justify*. Explain what they require in this assignment, using a short example.

Example — Public health

"'Evaluate the intervention' means making a judgement about its effectiveness using evidence. Consider its strengths and limitations, then explain your overall judgement."

Show how this differs from description:

Description	Evaluation
"The intervention provides weekly workshops."	"The workshops improved participants' knowledge, but limited attendance reduced their reach. This suggests that the intervention needs a more accessible delivery approach."

Explain that the evaluation would need supporting evidence. A task-word definition alone does not establish the specific expectations of your assignment.

3. Show how the assessment criteria apply

Choose a criterion and translate it into features students can recognise in their work.

Example — Engineering

Criterion: Justification of design decisions.

Explain: "State the decision, explain why it meets the design requirements, and support your reasoning with relevant calculations, standards or test results."

Use a short extract to demonstrate where these features appear. Then ask students to locate them in another extract.

Clarify which criteria assess subject knowledge, reasoning, communication or other outcomes. Explain language expectations in line with the published criteria.

4. Discuss examples of different quality

Use authorised, anonymised student work or teacher-created extracts. Select examples that help students see a meaningful difference against a particular criterion.

How to do it

1. Display the criterion and two short extracts.
2. Ask students what each extract demonstrates.
3. Have them identify evidence for their judgement.

4. Explain your assessment and how the weaker extract could improve.

Example — Economics

- **Extract A:** "Prices increased during the period."
- **Extract B:** "Prices increased as demand grew faster than supply. The rise in orders alongside stable production supports this explanation."

Ask: "Which extract explains the change? Where does it connect a concept with evidence?"

Use several examples over time so students see that successful work can take different forms.

5. Make subject conventions and permitted support explicit

Identify expectations that students may not infer from the task title. Explain them with a short example where useful.

Area	What to clarify
Structure	Required sections, their functions and any flexibility in organisation.
Evidence	Suitable sources or data, and how students should use them to support claims.
Referencing	The required system and what needs acknowledgement, including figures and tables.
Collaboration	Which activities students may do together and which work must be completed individually.
Tools and assistance	What is permitted, any limits and how use must be acknowledged.

Example — Science

"The results section reports your findings. The discussion interprets them and relates them to the research question and relevant literature."

For assistance and tools, use wording consistent with institutional rules and the specific assessment:

"For this assignment, you may use [permitted support] for [purpose]. You must complete [specified work] independently and acknowledge assistance by [method]."

Replace the brackets before sharing the guidance. Include how students can check permission if they are uncertain.

6. Check students' interpretation early

Ask students to demonstrate how they understand the task before they invest substantial time.

Use a short planning activity:

Prompt	Student response
What must you produce?	A brief description of the output and audience.
What thinking does the task require?	The comparison, explanation, evaluation or other reasoning needed.
What will support your response?	Proposed evidence and relevant course concepts.
What remains unclear?	A specific question, if needed.

Example — Public policy

"Outline your proposed recommendation, two criteria you will use to judge the options, and the evidence you expect to draw on."

Review for misunderstandings about scope, reasoning or evidence. Share common clarifications with everyone.

Explain that feedback checks whether the approach fits the task; students remain responsible for developing and supporting their own conclusions.

A short routine to try

When introducing your next assignment:

1. Explain its purpose, task and required output.
2. Unpack one important task word.
3. Apply one criterion to a sample extract.
4. Clarify conventions and permitted assistance.
5. Ask students to outline their approach and identify questions.

Supporting Sources

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